achieved by 2050, including a substantial increase in the area covered by natural, nondegraded ecosystems and a halt to the human-induced extinction of threatened species. The conference also acknowledged that these and other targets were unattainable unless Indigenous peoples and local communities (IPLC) were fully involved.

In 2021, the International Union for the Conservation of Nature (IUCN) had reported that 91 percent of lands occupied by IPLC were in a good or fair condition and that, globally, 36 percent of the land area covered by key biodiversity areas lay within these territories. In other words, the ecology of areas in which Indigenous peoples live tended to be healthier than most of the Earth’s land surface.

These figures show how IPLC custodianship is often consistent with conservation and the maintenance of biodiversity. Many IPLC livelihoods rely on the sustainability of their natural environment for their food, water, and other resources. These communities' close relationship with the environment means that they are usually the first, and most severely, impacted by environmental degradation. In addition, all too often they have been excluded from meaningful decision-making. It was not until the 2021 UN Climate Change Conference COP26, for example, held in Glasgow, UK, that IPLC were directly engaged in discussions with governments on climate change solutions at the global level.